

Vertigo

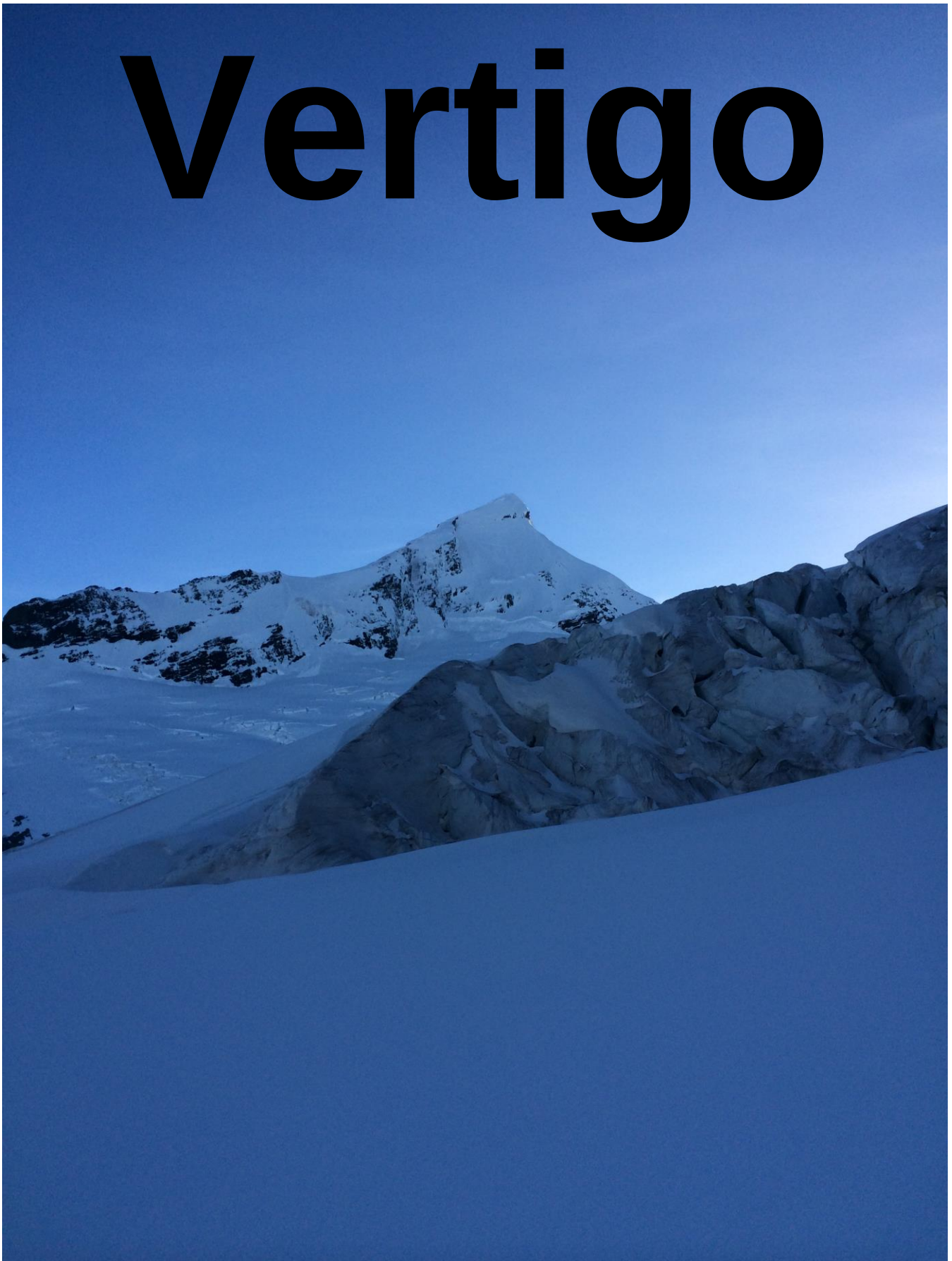


Photo Mt Aspiring from Bevan Col at dawn (Photo: Nina Sawicki)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section
www.facebook.com/nzacwellington

Section News

August section night

We've had a change of plan for the August section night. We had planned for the section night to showcase the winning photos from the Wellington Section Photo competition. The closing date for the photo competition has now been extended to 1 October with the winning photos to be shown at the October section night on 13 October. For details see below.

We're lucky enough to have Derek Cheng coming along to present at the August Section night instead. So come on a worldwide rock climbing trip with Kiwi traveller and dedicated dirtbag Derek Cheng, who spent more than two years sampling rock from Australia to Malaysia, Taiwan to China, Laos to Thailand, sweeping granite faces in Canada, tufa-filled limestone in Greece and Turkey, and the barely touched quartzite of southern Morocco. Complete with a selection of kick-ass photos and all the beta you need to quit your job and embrace the world of the climbing bum.

Section Nights are usually at the Tararua Tramping Club clubrooms, 4 Moncrieff Street, Mount Victoria, Wellington on the second Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings start 8.00 pm with tea & coffee afterwards

Upcoming Events

Wellington Section Photo Competition

Calling all budding photographers. The closing date for the 2014 Wellington section photo competition has been extended to 1 October so you have some time to dig through your photos and get them through for judging.

HOW TO TAKE PART

1) Pick out your best pictures for the following categories:

ALPINE ACTIVITY: climbing, skiing, whatever you do up high

ALPINE GENERAL: scenery and views that make you want to come back

ALPINE NATURE: the little gems of beauty along the way

ROCK CLIMBING: hardest moves, slickest lines

PHOTOJOURNALISM: the shot that tells a story

HUMOUR: whatever gets you a laugh

2) Download the entry form [here](#). Complete the form and email it to wgtntsectionphotocomp@gmail.com

If entering slides or prints please scan them first – we need all entries to be in digital format. Maximum of three entries per category per person – thanks!

For further info, contact Julian Davidson by email at wgtntsectionphotocomp@gmail.com

Learn to Ski-tour Course – August / September

This August and September, the Tararua Tramping Club is repeating last year's successful Learn to Ski-Tour Course and we would like to open this year's course to NZAC members. Full details of the course can be found on

<http://www.ttc.org.nz/pmwiki/pmwiki.php/TTC/SkiTouringInstruction>



Applicants must be intermediate level or better skiers who have completed a basic snow craft course and an Avalanche Awareness Course. For those who have not completed an Avalanche Awareness Course, the TTC organises a RAL operated course that applicants can attend prior to the start of ski-touring instruction. NZAC members do not need to join the TTC to do the course.

Remarkables Ice and Mixed festival 14 – 17 August 2014

SO WHATS THIS FESTIVAL ALL ABOUT?

- Bringing together a huge cross section of climbers from around NZ and the world.
- Beginners get to rub shoulders and share the rope with the top winter alpine climbers in NZ.
- Clinics, competitions, races and social gatherings advance and promote modern mixed climbing.
- Showcasing the new and existing route potential on NZ's most accessible multi pitch winter training area The Remarkables.
- Sharing local knowledge and forming new climbing partnerships.
- Fundraising for the NZAC expedition fund.

There are limited places available on the clinics and discounts available for NZAC members so be quick to secure your place. Full details on the festival can be found at

<http://www.iceandmixedfestival.co.nz/#>

NZAC Wellington Snowcraft 2014 Course 15th-17th August

WHAT: Learn snow craft basics – balance and movement, ice axes and crampons and an introduction to mountain awareness.

HOW: One week-night gear and logistics session (30th July) and a weekend away at the Tukino Alpine Sports Club on the eastern flank of Mt Ruapehu (15th-17th August).

COST: \$230 (Includes: accommodation and food). Gear hire and Alpine Club membership are additional costs.

If you are not currently an NZAC member, then you will also be required to join to participate in this course.

The pre-course evening is on Wednesday 30 July 6.00-8.00pm – Bivouac, Mercer Street, Wellington.

If you would like to register for this course, please download the registration form by clicking [here](#).

If you have questions email us at: wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

You can email your completed registration form to the same address as well.



If the weather or conditions prevent the course running on 15th -17th August, an alternate date has been set aside on 29th – 31st August. If the course successfully runs on 15th – 17th August, the alternate weekend would be available for those participants who would like to attend a club trip where they can practise their new found skills.

Cost of NZAC Membership can be found by clicking [here](#)

Benefits of the NZAC membership include:

- A 1 year subscription to the quarterly publication of 'The Climber Magazine'
- A copy of the NZ Alpine Journal.
- Discounted rates on all NZAC huts as well as DOC huts.
- Discounts at selected outdoor retailers and partners.

For a full list of benefits, please visit the NZAC website <http://alpineclub.org.nz/benefits-of-membership>

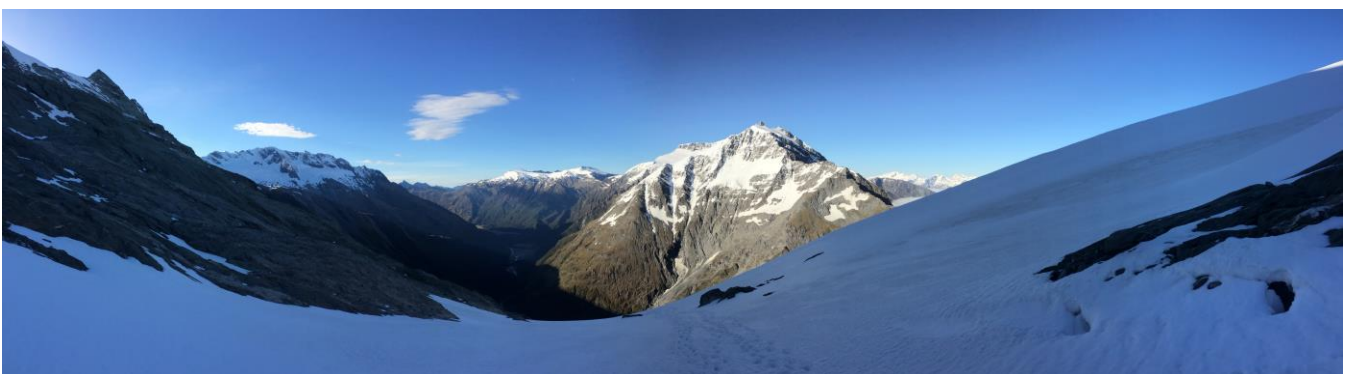
Trip Reports

Tititea: North West Ridge January 2014

Rob Hawes, Mark Henson and Nina Sawicki

Late December and early January 2014 had unseasonably late snow and a series of cold fronts. Rob, Mark and I had planned to do the full North West ridge over this period and were "waiting and watching like hawks" for our weather window. We pored over weather maps and watched the snow flurries on the surrounding hills of Wanaka. We walked into Aspiring Hut at the tail end of a front on Wednesday evening 06/01 (munching dinner on the way) and joined the throngs of walkers and frustrated climbers holed up there due to the weather. We rose early and left Aspiring Hut at about 5.00 am to make our way up to the head of the valley and then through the lower slabs below Bevan Col. The weather was sunny and calm but cool: just perfect. The bridge at Scotts Creek Biv has been taken out by an avalanche out necessitating an icy crossing over the upper Matukituki. The lads were quite precious about keeping their feet dry and walked up in approach shoes, and then changed to boots for the slabs. I just charged across in my boots. This is an eternal dilemma in the New Zealand Mountains: to carry more weight to begin with and have dry feet or carry less weight but face colder feet higher up and on the day of the climb.

At the head of the valley below the waterfall (before the slabs) we had a bite to eat in the sun and donned our harnesses. We heard a plethora of choppers making their way up to the Bonar Glacier (the first fine day for at least nine days) and knew the guided parties would beat us to the bunks but we enjoyed the gradual connection with the mountains and the increasingly alpine terrain. The climb up through the slabs is not technically difficult but is quite exposed high above the creek and on tiny (still) damp ledges with mountaineering boots and small holds. We did not use the rope but on more than one occasion I was very grateful for the encouragement from Rob to trust my feet and consistently work my way up. Once through the lower slabs the rest of the route up was straightforward on nice dry rock and then on to the snow at about 1600m and a steady plod up to the col. We did not need our crampons until we reached the col and headed onto the glacier.



Looking from Bevan Col to the Matukituki : Photo Mark Henson

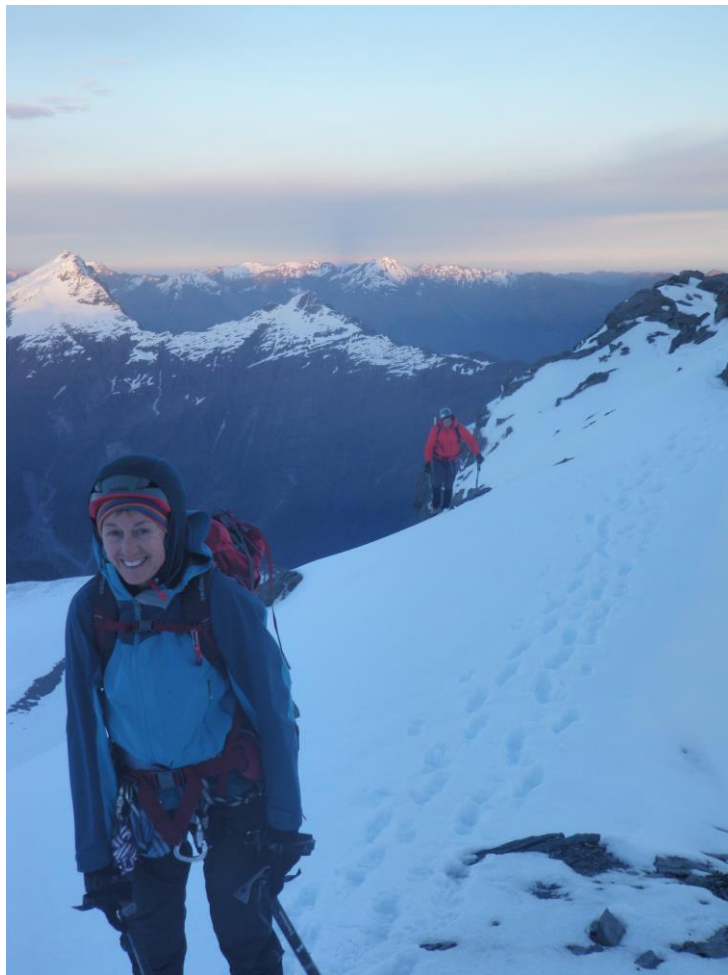
The conditions were perfect even in the early afternoon and we worked our way across steadily to Colin Todd arriving about 2.30 pm. We spent some time discussing the route and it was obvious the full North West Ridge would not be an option due to verglas on the lower rock so

we decided we would climb up the Kangaroo Snow field and join the ridge the just before turned it on to the Therma face. Mark cooked us a great feed of sautéed tofu for our day ahead. We even managed to find a bunk but the hut was full to capacity with bodies on the floor (not unusual for Colin Todd Hut).



Reflection of Mount Aspiring on Mt. Iona : Rob Hawes and Nina Sawicki: Photo Mark Henson

The next day was perfect: cool, calm, clear and frosty and we set off about 4.00 am. Mark started the day with an enthusiastic morning leap through the crust into a slot by the hut and had an embarrassing extraction from concrete snow. The route up the snow field was straightforward and we let the guided parties head out first. At the head of the snow field we turned onto the exposed Therma face working below a rock step and then climbed up to join the ridge proper. The conditions for "two tooling" were excellent with firm snow/ice and so I was able to solo across the face following Rob with his steady encouragement before climbing up to the crest of the ridge. At this point we passed numerous guided parties as they short roped the clients up. The route along the ridge was breathtakingly beautiful with the Bonar and Therma clear and visible on either side of the ridge. The ridge was narrow in parts and required some delicate foot and crampon work on the mixed rock and ice but the snow conditions on the ridge were excellent (even on the descent later that morning).



Nina Sawicki and Mark Henson along the NW Ridge : Photo Rob Hawes

We soon joined the top of the ramp (at about 7.00ish) and then climbed steadily up to the summit which we reached at about 9.00 am. We did not need the rope at all.



Nina Sawicki and Rob Hawes : Summit Madness on Mt Aspiring : Photo Mark Henson

It was interesting to climb a peak for the second time and a few people have asked why I wanted to climb Aspiring again. This was a totally different experience: I enjoyed the ridge more than the ramp as the terrain was more varied and I found the climb up and along the ridge more interesting than the ramp which did not offer as many vistas for the eyes to feast on. I was in a better head space and had more trust in my foot work which meant I had more energy to enjoy the beauty of the environment.

The descent did require two abseils down on the Therma face and across the rock step which Rob led. The snow by now was softening so we could not be confident our footsteps would hold. There was the start of the odd rock fall in warming conditions which encouraged us to move quickly.

We got back to Colin Todd hut about 2.00 pm and I enjoyed endless cups of tea. The hut was mostly empty by 6.00 pm as most of the guided parties were down by then and away in helicopters. Mark and I watched keas play and scrap on the hut roof, swooping, diving and scrapping over anything they could while Rob cooked dinner. The walk out the next day was straightforward but we did two abseils down the lower slabs.

We had a competition for the tastiest meal, which Rob won, but I had the yummiest treats. The whole mountain experience was wonderful and the company a bit cheeky at times. According to mountain maestro Don French we timed it right: we walked in to the last "pitter-patter" of rain and walked out in a soggy down pour.

Alpine Instructor Development at Temple Basin

Dan Pringle, China Yu, Jesse Bailey, Paul Bird and Sharron Came.

Early July saw five Wellington Section members descend on Temple Basin ski field for a weekend of instructor development. Each year NZAC arranges food, accommodation and some qualified guides for a weekend of developmental activities for section nominees, usually people who help run section alpine instruction courses. I have been fortunate enough to attend the last two instructor development sessions. They are a great way to pick up new ideas about how to teach basic alpine skills and to network with other instructors throughout New Zealand. NZAC is very keen for more volunteer instructors to get their NZOIA 1 and 2 qualifications. While working at getting qualified takes up valuable free time, the qualifications ensure your skills are recognised. There is funding available to help people get qualified. If you are interested contact the Wellington Section Committee for more information wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

So what did we do with our weekend? On Friday night we braved the sleet to walk up to the Temple Basin ski field lodge. After a few hot drinks and a chat with other late arrivals we headed off to bed. Saturday, after a hearty breakfast and a quick briefing session, we were outside to practise walking in snow. The groups were divided into three with the most experienced instructors grouped with Andy Cole, the guide contracted by NZAC to write the draft instruction manual, another group with avalanche expert Penny Goddard and ourselves plus Fraser from Otago Section and Lewis, a Fox Glacier Guide with the legendary John Entwistle.

The opportunity to hang out with John Entwistle was my main motivation for heading south again. He was our guide last year and I really enjoyed his irreverent, down to earth approach to instruction, not to mention his wicked sense of humour, Yorkshire accent and deep appreciation of good red wine, women and cheese. Team Entwistle immediately headed out into the bright sunshine for some walking in snow practise followed by sessions on self- arrest and alpine shelters.



We spent a lot of time focusing on how to teach stuff in an integrated way using all five senses, your body and the surroundings (environment). John is a big fan of empowering

students. This involves taking care of the safety fundamentals while letting the students make their own discoveries and mistakes. The approach is open, flexible and intuitive. No world authorities. No talking heads. We got lots of practical tips for integrating weather, terrain, avalanche risk, snow conditions and movement with what to wear, what to eat and how to make decisions by linking them to consequences.



Team Entwhistle

Saturday afternoon, because it was there, we climbed Mt Blimit. This “lesson” provided us with great views, a collective sense of purpose and an excellent opportunity to apply the skills learnt in the morning. We got to have fun while thinking about assessing descent routes on the way up and figuring out turn-around times. Climbing Mt Blimit was classic Entwhistle – be spontaneous, communicate your passion for the alpine environment to your students and, after careful consideration of the consequences, base the day’s activities on the skills and experience of the group.

Saturday night, after a fabulous dinner and sharing of tall climbing stories, we all gathered for a robust debate about the contents of the draft instruction manual. This was followed by an impromptu hut traverse competition led by the alpha monkeys from each section. Sensitive as always to the risks of humiliating the other sections Welly section merely observed these goings on.

Sunday, after another briefing session focusing on how to use the risk assessment form in the draft manual (for assessing weather and avalanche risk and relating this to the day’s planned activities), we headed out again into the bright sunshine. As John rightly pointed out, when the weather and snow conditions are mint, time spent filling out activity forms should be strictly limited. Team Entwhistle practised snow anchors, belay set up and basic pitching systems followed by some transceiver searching. These sessions were useful for emphasising that teaching anchors, belaying and basic pitching is not as straight forward as you might think with many possible variations.

The weekend ended with a good lunch, formal induction of Fraser and Lewis as honorary members of Wellington Section and some final lessons indoors on what to wear, how to wear it, and tips for stashing it. Then it was handshakes all round and trying not to feel too jealous

about John's forthcoming adventures in France and Italy we headed down the hill to Arthurs Pass Village well satisfied with our two days with The Man from Yorkshire.

Mt Rolleston – thank you Mr Entwistle

Limited wind and unlimited sunshine provided a big stage on which we played out our collective struggle to cope with the rather large distraction of unobstructed views of Mt Rolleston and Mt Philistine on the other side of the valley. Climbing Mt Blimit on Saturday afternoon just made things worse. "What shall we do tomorrow?" asked John Entwistle our mentor for the weekend. "Climb Mt Rolleston" I suggested hopefully. Yeah nah. Sunday was reserved for building snow anchors and belaying followed by transceiver search practise. Rolleston is one of those rare peaks, highly accessible by New Zealand standards if the weather co-operates. Big highs in early winter are rare. Would the high stick around for another day? We were really keen to have a go at climbing Rolleston via the Rome Ridge, one of the classic day climbs in Arthur's Pass National Park. With some of the party having flights back to Wellington in the evening though, we weren't sure if we would have enough time to complete the route. In good snow conditions travel is reasonably quick but there are many tales of parties getting bogged down in soft snow or needing to do a lot of pitching on the exposed sections of the ridge, particularly the steep gully that provides access to the low peak, above the broken piece of ridge guarded by a gnarly buttress referred to as "the gap".

We were aware that a CMC party had completed the route a fortnight earlier, using two pitches and taking 10 hours. They reported back that the snow was thin and icy and that the route felt more like a grade 3 than a 2. Descending from Temple Basin to our base for Sunday night, the NZAC Lodge at Arthur's Pass we spotted a pair of climbers descending Rome Ridge. Checking out the hut book at the Lodge we saw that a party of 4 from Christchurch had set out that morning to climb Rolleston. A few hours later while we were sitting in the pub discussing our options a pair of gorgeous women climbers, fit, sunburned and wearing big smiles, entered. We didn't need Entwistle to tell us to strike up a conversation with them. China was handicapped by being on his mobile. I had no idea Dan could move so quickly. It turned out the climbers had just returned from a successful ascent of Rolleston and worried about their male companions who had turned back just prior to "the gap" as they didn't fancy the snow conditions. We were able to reassure them that their companions were on their way down. In return they provided us with detailed information on the route and snow conditions including photos. Crucially they gave us the encouragement we needed to make the decision to commit to giving the route a go on Monday. Shortly afterwards the rest of their party arrived at the pub – a happy ending to a great day out for them.

Back at the Lodge tension and excitement mounted in equal measure as we sorted out our gear and set our alarms for 3am. We planned to start the climb at 4am to give ourselves plenty of time to get up and down and back to Christchurch for flights. We were sharing the Lodge with a group from the Auckland Section of NZAC who planned to climb Rolleston via the Otira Slide (the standard descent route), or to climb Avalanche Peak. They were taking a rather more relaxed approach to their preparation - bustling about cooking, enjoying their wine and beer. Animated gear discussions were liberally punctuated by door banging, plastic bag rustling and gales of hysterical laughter. In an attempt to zone out the chaos, I read the highly amusing stories of chaos in the latest edition of Antics. I was fortunate in that I had bagged a spot in the warden's room so all my gear was in one place and nobody showed any interest in using my

door as a turn-style. However, it transpired that a fellow hut dweller had an unrivalled talent for scorching steaks. The ensuing fumes caused the smoke alarm situated on the ceiling above me to squeal relentlessly. Leaving me to ponder one of life's eternal questions, should I disable the smoke alarm or disable the steak scorcher?

At 3am the team quietly assembled in the main room to eat breakfast and make final preparations. After clearing the ice off the car windscreen we were off to the Coral Track car park where we carefully hid the car key under a rock. Not carefully enough though. If you are going to leave an electronic car key stashed in the bush put it inside a plastic bag so it doesn't freeze! We headed up the Coral Track at 4am with China in the lead. Conditions were mild and I was wondering how soft the snow would be as we sweated our way up to the bush-line. As it turned out the snow conditions were fine. We were able to switch to crampons after about half an hour on the ridge. We had footprints from the day before to follow and the lights of State Highway 73 and Arthur's Pass village to remind us how far we had ascended already.



Early morning start with Jesse, Dan, Sharron and Paul

On the ridge a slight breeze ensured we did not overheat and travel was quick and smooth. At about 7am we paused just before the buttress that blocks the way to "the gap" to put on our harnesses and have a snack. China took a few pictures of the breaking dawn which was lovely.

It was too cold to linger and we were keen to get the crux of the climb done. We had timed things perfectly with daylight likely to arrive just as we hit "the gap". China, Jesse and Paul took the lead as we descended 100m to traverse around the buttress to "the gap" with Dan and I following behind.



Dan and Sharron on the good stuff early morning

At the base of the gap we climbed up single file each waiting for the other to reach safer ground so as not to be showered with ice chips, loose snow or a falling body. Once we were all together again we eyed up the next move which was an exposed traverse to the base of the last steep section of the gully which guards access to the ridge that leads to the low peak. The consensus was that it would be prudent to belay the lead climber across and set up an anchor so the rest of the party could clip into the rope and then move up with the last person being belayed up. After that the route looked fine for soloing.



Sharron traversing Rome Ridge



Jesse Dan Sharron and Paul on ridgeline on Rome

Paul led off belayed by Jesse. It turned out the traverse was more straightforward than it looked from a distance. Even so Paul placed intermediate protection and we stuck with our plan. Jesse followed Paul up, then me, Dan and finally China was belayed up, cleaning up the gear as he came. By now the sun was on our face (the snowy one more than our mugs) and the snow was softening rapidly. Paul and I continued climbing above the anchor on the slopes that lead to the summit. The climbing was excellent – firm to icy snow and the views were great.



The Team on Low Peak summit looking across to High Peak of Rolleston

We reached the summit a bit before 10am just after the first of the Auckland Section team. We spent a bit of time enjoying the views and taking pictures then Jesse, Dan and China arrived. By 10.30am we had finished with our touristoramas and it was time to start descending. We got a few tips from our Auckland colleagues then headed down the slide. The descent involved lots of down climbing in softening snow followed by comfortable wading facing outwards. The lads were significantly quicker than me on the down climbing but China was very patient, giving me a few tips and words of encouragement. We checked out the Otira Face. It looked intimidating.



Paul, Dan, Sharron and Jesse descending the Otira Slide

A pleasant walk down the lower Otira Valley saw us at the road in good time, 9 hours 18 minutes and 13 seconds after we set off. Yes, Jesse timed it. With the car parked a few kilometres away we debated whether we should all walk to it before deciding that Paul should don Jesse's trainers and go fetch the car. Meantime China flagged a car down so Paul could get a lift, problem solved. In no time at all we were back at the Lodge packing up and cleaning up and basking in the memories of the first alpine climb of the season and a great day out in the hills.

Big thanks to the team for a beaut three days in the hills. Particularly Dan, Jesse and China who carried the ropes!

Notices

2014 NZ Alpine Club Photographic Competition

Entries are open for the 2014 NZAC Photographic Competition. Rules, information and a useful document written by Mark Watson providing tips for better climbing photos can be found at <https://alpineclub.org.nz/photocomp>. Entries close on 1 August 2014 so be in quick with your photos!

1080 drop Iris Burns Valley, Fiordland

For those who are planning on using the Kepler area, please see the Public Notice for the aerial 1080 operation commencing 4 August 2014 in the Iris Burn Valley, and the Iris Burn Valley Battle for Our Birds Factsheet at <https://alpineclub.org.nz/news/2014/public-notice-1080-drop-iris-burns-valley-fiordland>.

Should you have any feedback, or would like to talk to someone regarding the operation, please contact:

[Lindsay Wilson](#) Conservation Services Manager, Department of Conservation

Wellington Rock guide book is on special

Wellington Rock is currently on special at \$10 + postage and packaging for Alpine Club members. Please log in online for member rates:

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/product/wellington-rock>

Looking for 70's Climbers

Seeking any past climber partners of Tom McNeight (former Wellington based member), during the 70's to 80's for information / images of his climbing at the time, please.

He used to ice-climb, but had a fall in Mt Cook on a private trip and could no longer climb. His friend Vicki would like to hear from anyone who knew him during this era.

Please contact Margaret@alpineclub.org.nz for Vicki's phone number.

New book available for sale : Guy - The Adventures of New Zealand Photographer Guy Mannering

Finally we can all witness the wonderful exploits of Guy Mannering... Photographer, Filmmaker, Jet Boater, Mountaineer, Adventurer.

This is a must-read and engaging recollection from Guy's diaries and his wife Margie's memories assembled and written by Margie and his granddaughter Nikki, proving once again that behind every great New Zealand story are the equally skilled and dedicated storytellers.

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/news/2014/guy-the-adventures-of-new-zealand-photographer-guy-mannering>

Campsaver – new member discount

A 20% online purchase discount on regular priced items is now being offered to NZAC members at <http://www.campsaver.com/> See their website Q&A for details on free shipping and brand exclusions. The online code for use at their checkout can be found on our new members-only page: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/membership/members-only>

Climber Magazine – going green

Keen eyes will notice some important changes with the 2014 winter issue of 'The Climber'. First thing to be seen for those receiving their magazine via post will be the change to the wrapping.



Greenmail wrap contains an additive composed of organic compounds that attract microbes when placed into a microbe-rich environment. It will biodegrade as the microbes use the carbon for energy and then leave nothing of the polymer behind when the process of digestion is complete.



Also note the Forest Stewardship Logo.

This indicates that the paper used in The Climber is made from timber harvested from well-managed, renewable and legally harvested forests. These are plantation, or commercial forests where the land has trees planted, harvested and new trees planted again.

Enjoy your cleaner greener Winter issue of 'The Climber'.

A 20% online purchase discount on regular priced items is now being offered to NZAC members at <http://www.campsaver.com/> See their website Q&A for details on free shipping and brand exclusions. The online code for use at their checkout can be found on our new members-only page: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/membership/members-only>

Wellington Section 2012/13 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Email alias*	Contact
Chairperson	Dan Pringle	chairperson	027 768-2185
Vice Chair	Vincent Zintzen	vicechair	
Secretary	Julian Davidson	secretary or CM2	
Treasurer	Adam Newberry	treasurer	
National Rep	Dan Pringle		
Patron	John Nankervis		
Trips	Vacant	Trips	
Other Committee Members	Simon Williamson		
	John Yu		
	Sharran Came		
Other Roles:			
Gear	vacant	gear	
Personal Locator Beacons	vacant	PLB	
Instruction Coordinator	vacant		
Instruction - AIC	vacant		
Instruction - Rock	vacant		
Library	Joke Meerkens	library	
Newsletter Editor	Carolyn Ellis		Kaz1963@gmail.com
Rock Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	drill or KF	
Website	John Yu	webmaster	
* Email address is: alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz eg. secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz			
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary			
Any media queries should be directed to:			
03 3777 595	National Executive Officer	Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



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